

Asset hunting: fonts, icons, photos, illustrations, legally and cheaply

Week 9, Lecture 2 · Design for Builders: Ship Beautiful Products as a Founder

Autumn 2026

What we will cover

- Google Fonts and Fontsource: what the SIL OFL actually permits
- Lucide, Phosphor, and Iconify: ISC and MIT and what they mean in practice
- Unsplash, Pexels, and Open Peeps: photos and illustrations without conditions
- Reading a license in under two minutes: five terms that cover 90% of cases
- When to pay: three cases where a commercial license is the right call

Part 1: fonts

Google Fonts and Fontsource

- Google Fonts: over 1,500 typefaces, almost all under the SIL Open Font License (OFL)
- Fontsource: the same fonts as npm packages for self-hosting (avoids a third-party DNS request in production)
- Both governed by OFL 1.1. Same license, different delivery mechanism.
- The OFL is the license on virtually every free typeface in active use

What the SIL OFL permits

- Use in logos, product names, marketing materials: permitted
- Embed in apps, software, and web fonts: permitted
- Redistribute as part of a larger work: permitted
- Modify the font for your own use: permitted
- Attribution: not required for use (only required for distributions of the font file itself)
- Source: SIL International (2022), openfontlicense.org/how-to-use-ofl-fonts/

What the SIL OFL prohibits

- Selling the font file alone (you cannot sell just the .ttf or .woff2): prohibited
- Using a Reserved Font Name on a modified version you distribute: prohibited
- Sublicensing under different terms: prohibited
- For product builders: none of these prohibitions affect normal use. Ship any Google Font freely.

The Reserved Font Name clause

- Some OFL fonts declare one or more “Reserved Font Names” in their license text
- If a font has an RFN, a modified version you distribute must use a different name
- The RFN does not restrict use, embedding, or modification for private use
- It only applies when you modify the font file and distribute the modified version publicly
- Practical impact for builders: zero. You are using the font, not re-releasing it.

Part 2: icons

The recommended icon stack

Lucide (ISC license)

Phosphor Icons (MIT license)

- ISC is a simplified BSD: use for anything, include the license file
 - No attribution in UI required
 - Satisfied automatically via npm install
 - Some icons derived from Feather Icons (MIT, same practical terms)
 - License: lucide.dev/license
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- MIT: use for anything, include the license file
 - Six weight variants: thin, light, regular, bold, fill, duotone

Iconify: the aggregator

- Iconify hosts hundreds of icon sets in one package
- Each set retains its original license. Iconify does not grant its own license.
- If you use a set through Iconify, follow the link to the original license for that set
- Lucide and Phosphor are both available through Iconify and carry the same ISC/MIT terms
- Do not assume all sets on Iconify are freely commercial. Check each set.

What “include the license file” means

- MIT and ISC require the license text to appear in copies of the software
- For an npm package, the license text lives in `node_modules/[package]/LICENSE`
- It is included automatically when you run `npm install`
- It does not need to appear in your app’s user interface
- You are compliant from the moment you install the package
- The license file is preserved in your compiled bundle if you use a standard bundler

Part 3: photos and illustrations

Unsplash

- Largest free high-quality photo library: over 5 million images
- Unsplash License: commercial use permitted, modification permitted, attribution not required
- Prohibition: you cannot resell or redistribute the raw image files as stock photography
- For product use: App Store screenshots, OG images, landing pages: all permitted
- License page: unsplash.com/license (read this page, not a blog summary of it)

Pexels

- Free photo and video library with millions of assets
- Pexels License: commercial use permitted, modification permitted, attribution not required
- Same prohibition as Unsplash: you cannot resell or redistribute the raw files
- Pexels also hosts video, which is useful for product demos and social content
- License page: pexels.com/license

Open Peeps by Pablo Stanley

- Hand-drawn human figure illustration system
- License: CC0 (public domain). No attribution. No restrictions. No conditions.
- Figma Community file: mix and match poses, expressions, outfits directly in Figma
- Can be modified, colored, combined with your brand assets, and shipped to the App Store
- One of the most useful free illustration resources for SaaS and consumer app marketing

Part 4: reading a license

Five terms that cover 90% of cases

1. **Attribution required.** Must you credit the creator? Unsplash: no. OFL: no (for use). CC BY: yes.
2. **No derivatives (ND).** Can you modify the asset? CC ND: no. Avoid ND in production work.
3. **Non-commercial (NC).** Does the license prohibit commercial use? CC NC: yes. A product with revenue is commercial.
4. **Reserved Font Name.** Can you redistribute a modified font under the same name? OFL RFN: no. Normal use is unaffected.
5. **Permissive (MIT, ISC, Apache 2.0).** Can you use for anything? Yes. Must include license text with the software. Satisfied by `npm install`.

How to read a license in under two minutes

- Open the license page (not a summary page, the actual license text)
- Search for “commercial”: is commercial use permitted?
- Search for “attribution”: is credit required?
- Search for “modification” or “derivative”: can you modify the asset?
- Search for “distribute”: can you include the asset in a distributed product?
- If you cannot answer all four questions from the text, the license is not sufficient evidence

The “free for commercial use” trap

- Many sites describe assets as “free for commercial use” without linking to a named license
- “Free for commercial use” is not a license: it is a marketing description
- The terms can change. Named licenses (CC0, MIT, OFL) do not change retroactively.
- Before shipping: find the named license, not just the description
- If there is no named license on the source page, the asset is not safe to use commercially

Part 5: when to pay

When to pay: three cases

1. **Editorial or news photography.** Identifiable persons, specific branded products, news value. Requires model releases and editorial rights that free photo sites cannot provide. Getty, Shutterstock, Adobe Stock.
2. **A complete, professional icon system.** Lucide and Phosphor have coverage gaps in specialized domains. If you need 300 icons and are finding workarounds for 20 of them, a pro set (\$49–99 one-time) buys visual consistency.
3. **A typeface with a voice free fonts cannot match.** A licensed typeface from a type foundry reads as genuinely distinctive. Licenses: \$30–300+ depending on desktop vs. web and page-view tiers.

Commercial typeface licenses: what to check

- Desktop license: covers use in Figma and design tools
- Web font license: covers serving the font from your production server
- App license: covers embedding in iOS/Android apps (separate from web)
- Most commercial foundries require separate licenses for each use type
- Read the license before you buy, not after. “Web” and “App” are not the same.

The terms can change. Named licenses do not change retroactively.

Take-aways

1. Google Fonts (SIL OFL): use in any product, no attribution, no restrictions on logos or apps. Free and legally clean for every founder use case.
2. Lucide (ISC) and Phosphor (MIT): permissive icon licenses. Compliant from the moment you npm install.
3. Unsplash, Pexels: commercial use, no attribution. Cannot resell raw files. Sufficient for App Store screenshots and OG images.
4. Open Peeps: CC0. No conditions of any kind. The safest illustration source available.
5. "Free for commercial use" without a named license is not a license. Find the named license or do not ship the asset.

What's next

- **Reading:** Week 9 reading covers both lectures plus a worked asset log example
- **Section (this week):** Asset studio. Build your favicon set, OG image, screenshots, and complete your license log before section ends.
- **HW 4 (due this week):** Brand sheet due
- **Week 10:** Capstone demo day. Every asset from this week is part of your launch package.